TEACHING NOTES FOR PRIMARY TEACHERS

Psychology of the Primary School Child

How young children grow, think, feel and learn - and what it means for your teaching every day

Clear, practical notes based on the educational psychology taught in the PST induction programme: child development, how learning happens, motivation, individual differences, play, language and classroom behaviour - explained in simple words, with a classroom example for every idea.

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Why a primary teacher needs psychology

Good teaching is not only knowing the subject. It is knowing the child in front of you - how that child thinks, feels, remembers and behaves at this age.



Educational psychology is the study of how people learn and how teaching can help them learn better. For a primary teacher it answers daily questions: Why does one child learn a poem in one reading and another needs five? Why does a child behave well in one lesson and disturb the next? Why does praise work on Monday and fail on Friday?

What these notes give you

- **How children grow** - the stages of development between ages 5 and 11, and what a child can and cannot yet do at each stage.
- **How children learn** - the main theories of learning, in plain words, and the teaching method each one points to.
- **How to respond** - motivation, emotions, behaviour and slow or fast learners, handled in ways that protect the child's confidence.

> **One idea to carry through every page:** a child is not a small adult. The primary child's mind works differently - it needs concrete things to touch and see, short steps, play, talk and encouragement. Teach the age, not only the book.

CHILD DEVELOPMENT

How children grow: stages every teacher should know

Children pass through stages in the same order, but not at the same speed. Jean Piaget described how thinking itself changes with age.

Piaget stage	Age	What it means in class
Sensorimotor	0-2 years	Learning through senses and movement. Mostly before school, but it explains why young children must touch and handle things.
Pre-operational	2-7 years	Language and imagination grow fast. Thinking is centred on one feature at a time and is hard to reverse. A Class 1 child may say the taller glass has "more" water even after watching you pour it.
Concrete operational	7-11 years	The child can reason logically - but only about real, concrete things. Sorting, ordering, grouping and simple cause and effect become possible with objects, pictures and examples in hand.
Formal operational	11+ years	Abstract and "what if" thinking begins. This is mostly a secondary-school stage - do not demand it from a Class 4 child.

The emotional stage: Erikson's "industry vs inferiority"

Between about 6 and 11, Erikson says the child's big inner task is to feel **competent** - "I can do things, I can learn, I can finish work." Every success builds industry; repeated failure, public comparison and harsh words build **inferiority** - "I am no good at this" - which a child can carry for years.

> **In the classroom:** set work each child can finish, show progress visibly (stars, portfolios, reading records), and compare a child only with his or her own past work - never with the best child in the row.

Growth is whole-child growth

- **Physical:** small muscles are still developing - handwriting, cutting and drawing tire young children quickly. Short tasks, movement breaks.
- **Social:** friends and group approval become very important from about age 8. Group work uses this strength.
- **Moral:** young children judge by rules and consequences ("it is wrong because teacher said so"); fairness and reasons matter more as they grow.

THEORIES OF LEARNING

How children learn: four views, four tools

No single theory explains all learning. A good primary teacher uses all four - each one is a tool for a different job.

1. Behaviourism - learning by practice and response

Pavlov and Skinner showed that behaviour is shaped by what follows it. Actions that are **reinforced** (praised, rewarded, succeeded) are repeated; actions that bring nothing fade. **Classroom use:** drills for tables and spellings, immediate feedback, praise and small rewards for effort and good habits.

2. Constructivism - learning by building understanding

Piaget's view: children are not empty vessels. They **construct** knowledge by connecting new ideas to what they already know, through doing, trying and sometimes being puzzled. **Classroom use:** start from what pupils know, use activities and discovery, let children handle materials and find patterns themselves.

3. Social learning - learning by watching

Bandura showed that children copy what they see - especially from people they respect. **Classroom use:** the teacher is a model all day. Demonstrate reading, kindness, neat work and calm behaviour; use able pupils as models for others.

4. Vygotsky - learning with a little help

Vygotsky's **Zone of Proximal Development** is the gap between what a child can do alone and what the same child can do with help. Teaching should aim inside that zone, and the help - called **scaffolding** - is slowly removed as the child grows able: hints, worked examples, sentence starters, a partner, then independence.

> **Too easy** bores the child. **Too hard** frightens the child. Work in the zone - just beyond what the child can do alone, with your support - is where learning lives.

THE LEARNING MIND

Memory, attention and thinking in young children

A primary child's mental "desk space" is small. Lessons that respect that limit are remembered; lessons that ignore it are forgotten by home time.

Attention is short - plan for it

- A rough guide is a few minutes of focused attention per year of age on one task. A 7-year-old cannot listen actively for a full period.
- **Change the activity, not just the topic:** listen, look, say, write, move, discuss - every 8-12 minutes.
- Attention follows interest and emotion. A question, a story, a real object or a small surprise re-opens wandering minds.

Memory grows with meaning and repetition

- **Working memory** holds only a few items. Give instructions in short steps, one at a time, and write them on the board.
- **Chunking:** group information - teach spellings in families, numbers in patterns, words in themes.
- **Repetition with gaps** beats one long drill: revise for five minutes today, tomorrow and next week.
- **Many senses store better:** see it, hear it, say it, write it, act it. Multi-sensory learning is not decoration - it is how memory works.

Thinking skills grow step by step

Young children think in pictures and actions before words and symbols. Follow the order **concrete, pictorial, abstract**: first real objects (counting stones, sticks, bottle caps), then drawings of them, and only then numbers and symbols alone. Skipping the first step is the most common cause of "weak in maths" in primary classes.

> **Forgetting is normal.** Plan revision into every week instead of blaming pupils. A two-minute recall starter - "write three things from yesterday" - strengthens memory more than re-teaching the whole lesson.

Motivation, emotions and self-esteem

Children learn with their feelings first. A child who feels safe, noticed and able will try; a child who feels afraid or worthless stops trying long before the lesson ends.

Basic needs come before books - Maslow

Maslow's hierarchy says lower needs must be met before higher learning happens. A hungry, tired, frightened or lonely child cannot concentrate on fractions. In class this means: notice the child who has not eaten, settle fear and bullying quickly, and make every child feel he or she **belongs** in the room.

Two kinds of motivation

- **Intrinsic motivation** comes from inside: curiosity, interest, the pleasure of "I did it." It lasts longest and grows with choice, challenge at the right level and genuine interest in the topic.
- **Extrinsic motivation** comes from outside: praise, stars, marks, prizes, parents' happiness. Useful, especially for young children - but if marks are the only reason, learning stops when marks stop.

Praise that builds, praise that harms

- **Praise effort and strategy:** "You kept trying different ways until it worked." This builds a growth mindset - the belief that ability grows with effort.
- **Avoid praising only cleverness:** "You are so intelligent" makes children fear failure, because failure would take the label away.
- Be specific, be honest, and praise in the moment. False praise is quickly detected and loses its value.

> **Self-esteem rule:** correct the work, never the child. "This sum needs another try" teaches. "You are careless" labels - and children live up to the labels adults give them.

INDIVIDUAL DIFFERENCES

No two children are the same

In one class of forty, there are forty different minds. Differences in ability, speed, language, home support and interest are normal - teaching must plan for them, not complain about them.

Many kinds of ability - Gardner

Howard Gardner's idea of **multiple intelligences** reminds us that "clever" has many forms. A child weak in written words may be strong in other ways:

Strength	Seen in a child who...
Verbal / linguistic	loves stories, words, telling and reading
Logical / mathematical	enjoys patterns, puzzles, numbers and "why" questions
Visual / spatial	draws well, remembers pictures, builds and arranges
Bodily / kinaesthetic	learns by doing, moving, making and acting
Musical	picks up rhythm, rhyme, songs and sounds easily
Interpersonal	works well with others, leads, helps and explains
Intrapersonal	knows himself, works thoughtfully alone
Naturalist	notices plants, animals, weather and the outdoors

Teaching at more than one level

- **Same topic, different depths:** a core task for all, support questions for those who need help, and a challenge question for fast finishers.
- **Different ways in:** let children show learning by drawing, speaking, acting or building - not only by writing.
- **Slow is not unable:** a slow learner usually needs more time, smaller steps and more practice - not a lower opinion from the teacher.
- **Watch for hidden barriers:** poor eyesight, hearing difficulty, hunger or trouble at home can look exactly like low ability. Check before you judge.

PLAY AND LANGUAGE

Play and language: how young children really learn

For a young child, play is not a break from learning. Play is the work of childhood - and language is the tool the mind thinks with.

What play builds

- **Thinking:** building, sorting, pretend play and games practise problem-solving, planning and cause and effect.
- **Social skills:** taking turns, sharing, rules, losing gracefully and working in a team are all learned in play first.
- **Language:** children talk most freely while playing - new words, full sentences, stories and arguments.
- **Emotional health:** play lets children express feelings, release stress and rehearse real life safely.

Protect time for play and activity in the primary timetable, and use game-like formats inside lessons too: quizzes as team games, maths with dice and cards, word hunts and role play. A lesson a child experiences as play is remembered as one.

How language grows

- Children learn language by **hearing it used and using it** - talk in class is learning, not noise, when it is talk about the work.
- **Stories are powerful:** listening to stories builds vocabulary, sentence patterns, imagination and the habit of reading.
- **Questions grow minds:** move beyond recall ("What is...?") to thinking questions ("Why do you think...?", "What would happen if...?").
- **The home language is a bridge:** a child thinks first in the language of home. Use it to explain and connect, then build the school language on top of understanding - never punish a child for the language he speaks at home.

> **Talk rule:** in a good primary lesson, children talk at least as much as the teacher. Silent copying is the weakest form of learning at this age.

CLASSROOM BEHAVIOUR

Understanding behaviour through psychology

Behaviour is communication. Before reacting to what a child did, the wise teacher asks what the child needed, lacked or could not yet do.

Common reasons behind common behaviour

Behaviour	Often it means...
Calling out, showing off	A need for attention and recognition - give attention for good behaviour first
Refusing work, "I can't"	The work feels too hard, or past failure has taught fear of trying
Restlessness, fidgeting	A young body that has sat too long; attention is exhausted, not character
Fighting, snatching	Social skills and words for feelings are still being learned
Daydreaming, silence	Boredom, confusion, worry from home - or a quiet intrapersonal learner
Copying in tests	Fear of failure and of adults' reaction to low marks

What psychology says works

- **Reinforce the positive:** behaviour that is noticed and praised grows. Aim to catch children being good far more often than you catch them being wrong.
- **Clear routines and few rules:** children feel safe when they know what happens next and what is expected - stated positively ("We walk in line"), agreed early, applied the same way every day.
- **Consequences, not fear:** a calm, related consequence (repair, apologise, practise the right way) teaches. Shouting, humiliation and physical punishment teach only fear and avoidance, and damage the trust all learning depends on.
- **Stay curious with difficult children:** the child who troubles you most usually needs you most. A private kind word often changes more than a public punishment.

QUICK REFERENCE

Problem, reason, response - a teacher's daily guide

You see	Think first	Respond by
Forgets yesterday's lesson	Normal forgetting; no revision built in	Two-minute recall starter; spaced revision each week
Cannot sit still in last period	Body and attention are tired	Movement break, active task, shorter listening stretches
Strong orally, weak in writing	Fine motor skills or spelling load, not understanding	Let him answer orally too; build writing in small steps
Finishes early, then disturbs	Work below his zone; boredom	Challenge question, helper role, extension task ready
Cries or withdraws at mistakes	Fear of failure; low self-esteem	Private, gentle correction; praise effort; easy win first

Chapter summary

- **Teach the age:** primary thinking is concrete - objects, pictures and actions before symbols.
- **Use all four tools:** practice and reinforcement, discovery, modelling, and guided help in the child's zone.
- **Feelings first:** safety, belonging and praise for effort unlock attention and memory.
- **Plan for differences:** many abilities, many speeds - one lesson, several levels.
- **Behaviour has a reason:** find it, reinforce the good, and protect every child's self-esteem.

Check yourself

- Which Piaget stage are most of your pupils in, and what does it demand from your lessons?
- Give one classroom example each of reinforcement, scaffolding and modelling.
- Why does praising effort usually work better than praising cleverness?
- Name a child strong in an intelligence your tests do not measure. How will you use that strength?